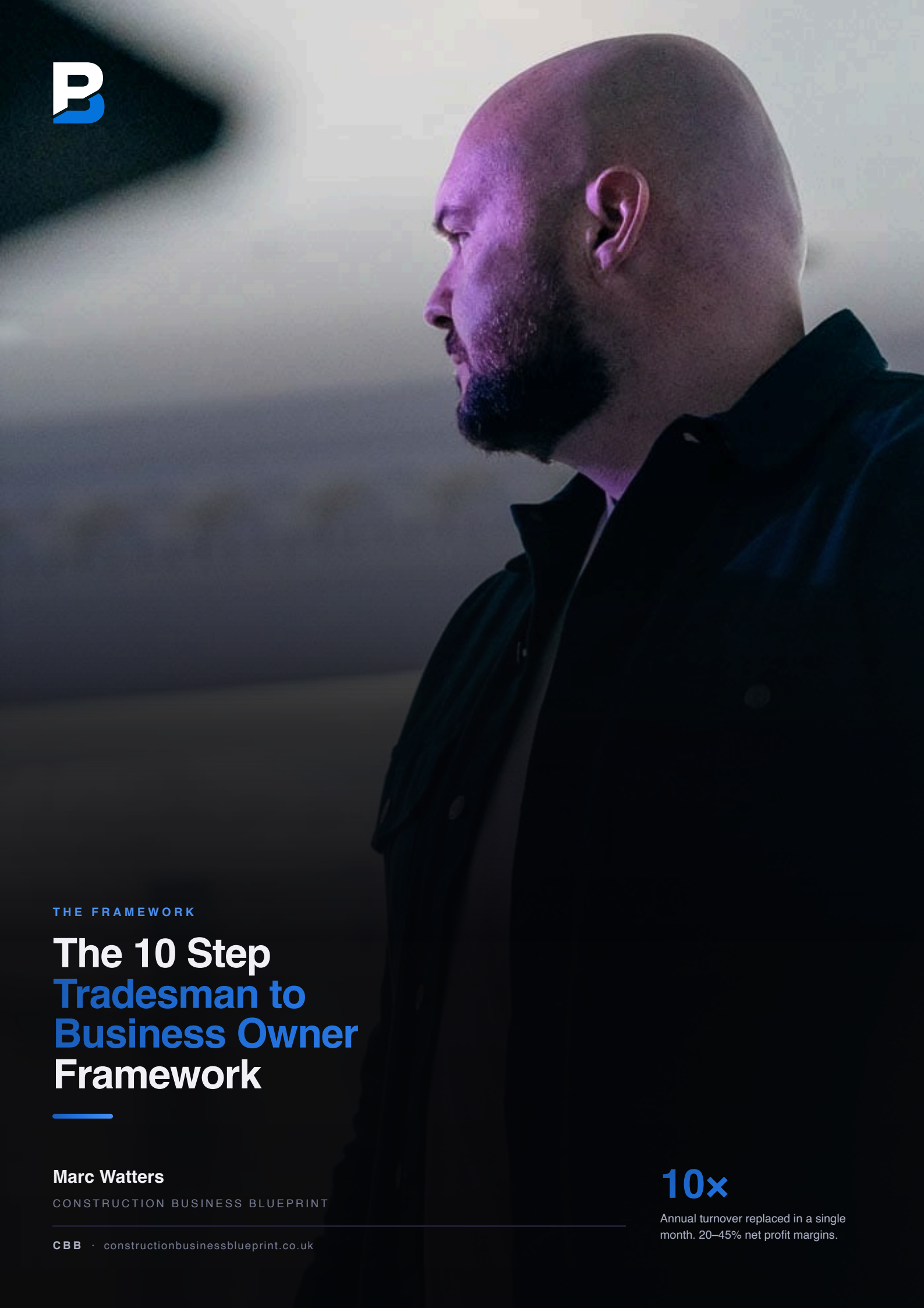

THE FRAMEWORK

The 10 Step Tradesman to Business Owner Framework

Marc Watters

CONSTRUCTION BUSINESS BLUEPRINT

10×

Annual turnover replaced in a single month. 20–45% net profit margins.

Before You Read This

This framework comes from one client. His name's Dan. He runs DE Landscapes.

Six months before we started working together he was on the tools six days a week. Pricing jobs at 10pm. Weekends gone. Head scrambled. Doing under 90 grand a year.

Six months in, he replaced his entire previous annual turnover in one month. Running between 20 to 45% profit margins, clear and absolute. Completely hands off the business. Off the tools. Built a team. Built the systems. Bought his dream home. Started investing in other businesses.

And for the first time in a long time, he's actually happy.

6 **Months.**
That's how long it took to go from 90k a year to replacing that in a single month.

20–45% **Net profit margins.**
Clear and absolute. Not estimated. Not hoped for. Known.

This isn't a motivational framework. It's not a mindset course. It's not a list of things that sound good in theory. It's the exact sequence of work we did together, in the order we did it, and why that order matters.

Read it in order. The steps build on each other. Skip one and the next one won't hold.

ABOUT MARC

Marc Watters has spent years in the construction industry — not watching from the sidelines, but in it. Managing large-scale commercial projects, running teams, dealing with contractors, cashflow gaps, and clients who moved goalposts.

Construction Business Blueprint is the result of everything he built and everything he learned along the way. It's not based on generic business theory. It's based on what actually works in this industry, with these clients, these timelines, these kinds of teams.

Why The Order Matters

Most business owners try to fix the wrong thing first. They jump to marketing when the real problem is the founder. They hire when the real problem is the systems. They buy software when the real problem is the pricing.

This framework is sequenced deliberately. Each step creates the conditions for the next one to work. You can't hand off the front end before you've built the systems. You can't rebuild the marketing before the business can deliver on what the marketing promises. You can't scale capacity before the foundation is solid enough to hold it.

The order isn't arbitrary. It's the order in which the problems actually need to be solved.

STEPS 01–02

Foundation

The founder and the calendar. Nothing else works until these are right.

STEPS 03–04

Clarity

Money and metrics. You need to know what the numbers are before you can change them.

STEPS 05–06

Structure

Systems and handoffs. The business starts to run without the founder in every detail.

STEPS 07–08

Growth

Leadership and marketing. Now you can grow without breaking what you built.

STEPS 09–10

Scale

Capacity and refinement. Build bigger, then strip out what stopped earning its keep.

The framework is designed to be worked through in sequence. That doesn't mean every step takes the same amount of time. Some founders move through Step 1 in a week. Others need a month. The pace is set by the business, not by a calendar. What matters is that each step is genuinely done before the next one starts.

Done means it's working. Not planned. Not started. Working.

STEP 01

Founder First. Business Second.

> Before any system, any tracker, any new hire, any marketing change. The founder has to be sorted first.

When Dan came to me, he didn't just have a business problem. He had a clarity problem. He didn't know what he wanted his life to look like, so he didn't know what he wanted his business to do. The result was a business that did everything to everyone, badly, and a founder running himself into the ground keeping it alive.

WHAT WE WORKED ON

We started with goal setting. Not generic business goals. Real goals. What he wanted his life to look like in 12 months, three years, ten years. What he wanted his typical week to feel like. What kind of business owner he actually wanted to be.

Then we worked on his vision for the business. What it should be doing, who it should be serving, what work it should be turning down. The business existed to serve the life. Not the other way round.

And then daily non-negotiables. The handful of things he commits to doing every day, regardless of what's on fire, that keep him aligned with the vision he's set.

THE SIGNS THIS IS BROKEN

- ✗ You can't articulate what "done" looks like for your business or your life.
- ✗ You're working harder every year and feel less in control every year.
- ✗ You take on jobs you don't want because you can't say no.
- ✗ You'd struggle to write down what your week is supposed to look like, never mind your year.

> **WHAT MOST PEOPLE GET WRONG.** They try to fix the business without fixing themselves. They install a new CRM, change their pricing, hire a marketing agency. None of it sticks because the founder is still chasing whatever shiny thing came in this morning. The business is a reflection of the founder. Fix the founder first.

STEP 02

Take Back Your Time.

> Once the founder has clarity, the next thing to fix is the calendar. Because the calendar is where intentions become actions, or where they go to die.

Dan's old week was a blur. On the tools Monday to Friday. Site visits squeezed into evenings. Pricing at 9pm with a scribbled notepad he could barely read in the dark. Weekends spent thinking about everything he hadn't got done. No structure. No protected time. No off switch.

WHAT WE WORKED ON

We started with a daily diary. Planning every day the night before. Catching the stuff that went off plan and writing down why. After two weeks of doing that, the leaks in his time became obvious. The same firefights. The same interruptions. The same low-value tasks eating his afternoons.

Then we audited those leaks one by one. What was Dan spending hours on every week that didn't actually grow the business? What jobs was he doing himself because "it's quicker if I do it" when really it was costing him days a month? What conversations was he having three times because there was no structure to them?

Each leak got plugged. Some by delegation. Some by batching, where site visits got grouped on Tuesday and Wednesday and pricing got grouped on Friday. Some by saying no. Some by building a process so it stopped happening at all.

THE SIGNS THIS IS BROKEN

- ✕ You're pricing jobs after dinner or at the weekend.
- ✕ Your phone is on from 7am to 10pm and you answer it.
- ✕ You don't know on Monday morning what your Thursday looks like.
- ✕ Your weekends are spent worrying about Monday.

> **WHAT MOST PEOPLE GET WRONG.** They try to add structure on top of the chaos instead of finding the leaks first. The diary fills with the same firefighting in tidier boxes. Real change means finding what's draining the time, plugging it, then building structure around what's left.

STEP 03

Fix The Money Mindset.

> This is the one most trade business owners flinch at. They've been quoting the same way for ten years. They believe their market "won't pay more." They've priced thousands of jobs on gut feel and they're attached to the way they've always done it.

Dan was the same. The first thing he flagged on day one was a fear of upselling. A fear of charging too much. A belief that adding things on would lose him the job. The problem was the jobs he was winning at those prices weren't worth winning.

> ***"The work I would have lost wouldn't have been worth doing anyway."***
>
> — Dan, six months in

WHAT WE WORKED ON

First, the beliefs. The belief that asking for a deposit makes you look unprofessional. The belief that increasing prices loses jobs. The belief that good clients are price-sensitive. The belief that you're not allowed to charge what you're actually worth.

Every one of those beliefs is a story. We changed the story. Dan stopped being afraid to ask for deposits. Stopped being afraid to put his prices up. Stopped competing at the bottom of the market. Stopped letting his pricing be defined by what he assumed people would pay and started letting it be defined by what the work was actually worth.

Then the pricing structure itself. We stopped pricing on gut feel. Every quote started carrying the cost of the work, the cost of running the business behind it, and a target profit. Profit became the thing the price was built around, not what was left over.

Deposits became standard. Payment terms got tightened. Dan stopped chasing money, because the structure stopped letting money be late.

THE SIGNS THIS IS BROKEN

- ✕ You don't know what your overhead actually is per month.
- ✕ You quote jobs and hope they're profitable rather than know they are.
- ✕ You worry about charging more in case you lose work.
- ✕ You're chasing money instead of doing the work.

> **WHAT MOST PEOPLE GET WRONG.** They confuse markup with margin. They build pricing around materials and labour and forget the actual cost of running the business. And the limiting belief never gets dealt with, so even when they know the right number, they don't have the spine to charge it.

STEP 04

Track What Matters.

> You can't improve what you can't see. And most trade business owners are running blind.

Dan's tracking on day one was a notebook and a memory. He had no idea which job types made him money. No idea what his real overhead was. No idea what his lead-to-quote-to-win ratio looked like. He had a feeling. Feelings aren't a strategy.

WHAT WE WORKED ON

We picked the numbers that actually move the business. Not a thirty-metric dashboard nobody looks at. The handful that, looked at every week, change what you do next.

- Monthly revenue, broken down by job type.
- Net profit margin, clear and absolute, after every overhead.
- Lead conversion rate, from inquiry to signed job.
- Average job value.
- Pipeline forward book — how much work is sold and waiting.

Then we set up the tools to capture them. Site reports going through Site Audit Pro on every job, so the work was documented properly and nothing got missed. Xero set up properly so the financial picture was live, not annual. A weekly rhythm where Dan looked at the numbers and made decisions on what they were saying.

With the numbers in front of him, Dan stopped guessing what was working and started knowing. Which job types made him real money. Which marketing channels actually brought in the right inquiries. Where the margin was leaking and where it was holding. The decisions stopped being arguments and started being maths.

THE SIGNS THIS IS BROKEN

- ✕ You don't know your real margin on the work you're doing right now.
- ✕ You can't say which type of job makes you the most money.
- ✕ You find out the business is in trouble at the end of the year, not at the end of the week.
- ✕ Big decisions get made on gut feel because there's no data to make them on.

> **WHAT MOST PEOPLE GET WRONG.** They track too much. They build dashboards with thirty metrics and check none of them. A handful of numbers, looked at every week, beats thirty numbers gathering dust. Pick the few that change behaviour and ignore the rest.

STEP 05

Build The Systems.

> A system is just "the way we do this every time." Most trade businesses don't have any. The way it gets done depends on who's doing it, what mood they're in, and how busy the day is.

On day one, Dan's systems were Dan. Quoting was Dan. Booking was Dan. Following up was Dan. Customer journey was Dan. The business couldn't operate without him because there was nothing to operate.

WHAT WE WORKED ON

Everything that happens in the business got mapped out into a process. Not in theory. On paper.

How a new inquiry comes in and what happens next. How a site visit gets booked, prepared for, and conducted. How a quote gets built, sent, and followed up. How a job gets booked into the calendar. How materials get ordered. How the customer gets updated through the project. How the invoice goes out and the payment comes in. How the job gets closed off and reviewed.

Each one written down step by step. Each one done the same way every time, by anyone, regardless of who's holding the phone.

The systems weren't fancy. A shared folder structure so every job had a home. Templated forms for the bits that get done over and over. Clear ownership so nobody was waiting for Dan to tell them what to do next.

BUILD THE SYSTEMS
The way it gets done should be the same every time, by anyone.

THE SIGNS THIS IS BROKEN

- ✕ If you're sick for three days, the business stops.
- ✕ Different team members do the same task three different ways.
- ✕ You're answering the same questions over and over.
- ✕ Things get missed because they live in your head, not on paper.

> **WHAT MOST PEOPLE GET WRONG.** They try to systemise everything at once and burn out. Or they document things in the wrong order and end up with beautiful workflows for tasks that don't matter. Start with the tasks that touch the customer and the money. The rest can wait.

STEP 06

Hand Off The Front End.

> This is the first real test of whether the founder can let go. And it's the one that changes how every customer experiences the business.

Dan was spending huge chunks of every day on tasks that were absolutely essential but didn't bring in value. Answering the phone. Booking site visits. Logging inquiries. Filling in receipt admin. Chasing suppliers. Each one a five-minute job. Together, half his life.

WHAT WE WORKED ON

Dan's partner Amy came into the business to run the front end. She had no construction experience. None. What she did have was a clear scope of what she owned, the systems we'd built in Step 5 to run the work through, and a weekly rhythm with Dan to keep things tight.

We mapped out every low-value-but-essential task Dan was doing himself and worked out which ones Amy could take on with the systems behind her. The phone. The booking. The inquiry log. The site-visit prep. The receipts. The Xero uploads. All of it lifted off Dan's plate and onto a structure that could run without him.

This wasn't about being cheap on labour. It was about Dan stopping spending his time on things that didn't grow the business. The front-end tasks were essential. They just weren't his job.

Now when a new inquiry comes in, Amy handles it. She qualifies the lead, books the visit, captures every detail Dan needs, and Dan walks onto the site visit with a brief in front of him instead of going in cold. The customer gets a professional first impression. Dan gets prepared. Both happen because the system is doing the work, not Dan's memory.

THE SIGNS THIS IS BROKEN

- ✕ You're still picking up the phone yourself.
- ✕ Inquiries get lost or forgotten because you were on a job.
- ✕ You arrive at site visits with no information about the job in front of you.
- ✕ Customers are chasing you for quotes you forgot to send.

> **WHAT MOST PEOPLE GET WRONG.** They hand off the work without handing off the structure. They give a new person the job but no script, no process, no checklist. Then it goes wrong, and they take it back and conclude "I have to do it myself." The handoff fails because the system to support it was never built.

STEP 07

Lead, Don't Manage.

> There's a difference between being on top of your team and being above your team. Most trade business owners don't lead, they hover. They're in every conversation, every decision, every site visit, every problem.

Dan used to be the bottleneck. Every question went to him. Every problem escalated to him. The team waited on him before they did anything that wasn't directly in front of them.

> ***"They'd be on to me if I hadn't done the Thursday meeting yet."***
>
> — Dan, on his team holding him accountable to the rhythm he installed

WHAT WE WORKED ON

We installed a weekly team meeting. Same day. Same time. Same format. A space for the team to surface what was happening on every job, what was about to go wrong, what they needed to keep moving. Issues got raised before they became fires.

We built a daily reporting rhythm so Dan knew what was happening on site even when he wasn't there. Walkthroughs at the end of each day. Photos. Quick voice notes. Enough information that he could trust the work was being done properly without standing over it.

And we worked on Dan's leadership itself. The hardest shift was him letting go of the belief that the team thought less of him for not being on the tools. They didn't. They thought more of him for trusting them with the work.

THE SIGNS THIS IS BROKEN

- ✕ Every decision, big or small, comes back to you.
- ✕ Your team brings you problems but never solutions.
- ✕ You feel like you're babysitting more than building.
- ✕ If you took two weeks off, you'd come back to a mess.

> **WHAT MOST PEOPLE GET WRONG.** They confuse delegation with abdication. They throw work over the wall and hope. Real leadership is setting the standard, the rhythm, and the accountability, then getting out of the way. Hovering and abandoning are both failures of the same thing.

STEP 08

Rebuild The Marketing.

> Now, and only now, do we touch marketing.

The reason most trade businesses fail at marketing isn't because the marketing is bad. It's because the marketing is pointing at a business that can't deliver on what the marketing promises. Steps 1 to 7 fix that. Step 8 turns the tap on. There are three shifts inside this step. Each one is non-negotiable. Skip any of them and the marketing leaks.

> ***"It was like a switch."***
>
> — Dan, on what happened the day the marketing identity changed

Shift 1 — Get Clear on the Business Identity

Most trade businesses describe themselves by their trade. "We're landscapers." "We're builders." "We do extensions." That's a category, not an identity.

Dan stopped being a landscaper and became a full garden transformation specialist. Same trade. Same skills. Different identity. The shift wasn't cosmetic. It defined what work he took, what work he turned away, what materials he used, what photographs he posted, and who looked at the business and said "that's for me."

Shift 2 — Identify Your Target Market

"Everyone with a garden" isn't a target market. The shift was getting clear on exactly who Dan was for. The kind of homeowner who cares about the materials, who has the budget for a proper transformation, who wants the finish to be right. Not the cheapest-quote-wins crowd.

When Dan stopped marketing to everyone, the inquiries got smaller in volume and bigger in value. The wrong people stopped calling. The right people started. Trying to be for everyone makes you for no-one. Get specific.

Shift 3 — Capture Your Market

Knowing your identity and your target market is one thing. Going out and actually winning the work is another. The third shift is where we put it all together. The actual plan for how Dan goes and gets in front of the right people, and what happens once he does.

It covers everything. What gets posted on social and how often. What kind of content does the heavy lifting and what's a waste of time. What the website says and shows. How inquiries come in, how they're qualified, how the first phone call goes, how the site visit gets prepped, how the quote gets sent. The whole journey, from a stranger seeing the business for the first time to signing the contract, mapped out and built to run the same way every time.

> **WHAT MOST PEOPLE GET WRONG.** They run ads to a website that hasn't been touched in three years, with a phone number that goes to voicemail, with photos of the wrong kind of work. The ad spend gets blamed for not working. The ad spend isn't the problem. The capture is.

STEP **09**

Build Capacity Without Building Chaos.

> Once the marketing's working and the right work is coming in, the question becomes how to deliver it. The instinct is to hire fast. The instinct is wrong.

WHAT WE WORKED ON

We started by streamlining the business. Looking at how the existing core team was being used. Were they on the right work? Was Dan still the bottleneck on the bits that needed his eye? Where were the gaps in capacity that were holding the team up? Before adding anyone new, we made sure the people already there were operating at their best.

Then we looked at outsourcing. What specialist work could a subcontractor handle better, faster, or cheaper than the core team? Dig-outs. Niche skills. Overflow capacity for the busy weeks. We built a vetted black book of subs Dan could call on. Brought in only when needed. Paid only when used. No payroll. No idle time.

The bigger piece was managing them. Because bringing in subcontractors doesn't help if you can't get the work out of them properly. We built the structure for how subs get briefed, what they're expected to deliver, how they're held to the standard, and how they're paid. The core team doesn't get diluted. The standard doesn't drop. The sub knows exactly what they're walking into.

The second squad came after that. Internal, structured, with a site lead, a defined role, the same systems and standards as the first team. Built deliberately on top of a foundation that was already proven.

THE SIGNS THIS IS BROKEN

- ✕ You're hiring in panic, not in plan.
- ✕ New people get added with no clear role and no system around them.
- ✕ Capacity goes up but margin goes down.
- ✕ Standards drop because the new lads don't know what good looks like.

> **WHAT MOST PEOPLE GET WRONG.** They try to scale before they've systemised. New people get hired into chaos and either leave, fail, or amplify the chaos. Capacity built on a shaky foundation collapses the foundation. Build the foundation first.

STEP 10

Review, Refine, Repeat.

> The work isn't done when the systems are built. The work is done when the systems are reviewed, refined, and the ones that aren't earning their keep are stripped out.

We installed two review rhythms.

WHAT WE WORKED ON

Weekly. Every week, the numbers get checked. Revenue. Margin. Lead conversion. Pipeline. Are the targets being hit? If not, what changed? What's the action this week to put it right? No drama. Just the weekly check.

Monthly. Once a month, the bigger picture. Are the systems actually working? Is the team on track? What's the win of the month? What's the leak? What's coming up that we need to plan for? It's the moment to step back, see the shape of things, and adjust.

And then a six-monthly and annual review on top of those, where the whole plan gets a proper look. What got built. What needs simplifying. What's earned its place. What's become busywork. The systems that aren't earning their keep get stripped out.

Over time the business gets sharper, not heavier.

THE SIGNS THIS IS BROKEN

- ✕ You added a tracker last year and you're not sure if anyone fills it in anymore.
- ✕ You're doing things because "that's how we do it" and nobody can remember why.
- ✕ The team has stopped raising issues because last time they did, nothing changed.
- ✕ You feel like you're working harder, not easier, the more systems you build.

> **WHAT MOST PEOPLE GET WRONG.** They confuse adding with improving. Every problem gets a new tracker, a new meeting, a new form. The cure becomes the disease. Real refinement means having the discipline to take things away.

What Happens Next

The framework works. But reading it and working through it are two different things.

Dan didn't get the results he got because he read a framework. He got them because he worked through it with someone who'd seen the same problems in dozens of businesses, knew what the fixes looked like, and held him accountable to actually doing the work.

That's what the mentorship is. Not a course. Not a group. One to one. Your business, your numbers, your team, your problems. A plan built specifically for where you are and where you're trying to get to, and someone in your corner every week making sure it moves.

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Places are limited. If it's a fit, we'll get on a call and go from there.

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